The Man to Send Rainclouds

Leslie Marmon Silko | Answers and Summary

Based on the supplied reading, pp. 92-97. Page references below refer to the printed page numbers.

Story summary

Leon and his brother-in-law, Ken, find Teofilo dead beneath a cottonwood tree near the sheep camp. They prepare his body according to their traditional customs, using a feather, colored paint, corn meal, and pollen. Leon asks his grandfather to send rain clouds. When they meet Father Paul on the road, Leon does not tell him that Teofilo has died. At home, the family dresses Teofilo in new clothes, holds a traditional funeral, and receives food and comfort from the community.

After the funeral, Louise suggests asking the priest to sprinkle holy water so that Teofilo will not be thirsty. Father Paul initially refuses because the family has not followed the Catholic burial practices he expects. He changes his mind and comes to the grave, although he still struggles to understand their customs. As he sprinkles the holy water, it reminds him of summer rain. Leon feels satisfied because he believes his grandfather can now send thunderclouds. The ending suggests that the family can include a Catholic ritual while keeping its own beliefs about death, rain, and the continuing connection between the dead and the living. (pp. 92-96)

First Response

Who do you think is "the man to send rainclouds"?

Teofilo is the man to send rainclouds. Leon asks him to "Send us rain clouds, Grandfather" and ends the story believing that he can send thunderclouds. Father Paul helps complete the burial, but Teofilo is the person Leon expects to bring rain. (pp. 92, 96)

Checking Up (True/False)

1. Teofilo had been herding sheep before he died.

True. He dies near the sheep camp, and Leon and Ken gather the sheep that have wandered away. (pp. 92-93)

2. Leon and Ken wrapped Teofilo's body in an old sheet.

False. They wrap him in a red blanket, not an old sheet. (p. 92)

3. Leon and Ken wanted holy water for Teofilo's grave.

True. Louise suggests it, and Leon asks Father Paul to bring holy water to the graveyard. (p. 94)

4. The priest offered to sprinkle holy water on the grave.

False. Leon asks him to do it. The priest initially refuses before deciding to come. (pp. 94-95)

5. The neighbors and clanspeople came to comfort Teofilo's family and leave food on the table.

True. They embrace the family and leave food for the gravediggers. (p. 93)

Talking It Over

1. The season of the year in which a story takes place is sometimes an important part of the story's setting. At what time of year does "The Man to Send Rainclouds" take place? How is the season important to the story?

The story takes place in March, near the end of winter or beginning of spring. Father Paul's thoughts identify the month, and the frozen topsoil and snow-covered mountains show that winter has not fully ended. The cold, dry setting makes rain and the coming growing season important. It also connects Teofilo's death with the family's hope that he will bring water and support new life. (pp. 92-93, 95-96)

2. To prepare Teofilo's body for burial, Leon and Ken perform a traditional ceremony. Why do they perform this ritual?

They perform the ceremony to honor Teofilo and prepare him for burial according to their beliefs. The feather, colored paint, corn meal, and pollen show their care for him and their respect for tradition. Leon's request for rain clouds shows that they believe Teofilo can continue helping the living after death. The ritual connects their love for their grandfather with the community's need for rain. (p. 92)

3. Father Paul tells Leon and Ken that they shouldn't allow Teofilo to stay at the sheep camp alone. Why is their response ironic, or the opposite of what we would expect? Why do you think they mislead the priest?

Leon says, "No, he won't do that any more now." Father Paul hears this as agreement to keep Teofilo from staying alone, but Leon knows Teofilo cannot return because he is dead. The reader understands something the priest does not, creating dramatic irony. Leon probably withholds the truth to avoid pressure to follow Catholic funeral practices and to let the family carry out its own ceremony first. This motive is an inference; Leon does not directly explain it. (p. 93; see also p. 95)

4. For both the Native American people and the Franciscan priest, water is an important part of the burial ceremony. Why do Leon and Ken change their minds about involving Father Paul?

Louise suggests having the priest sprinkle holy water so that Teofilo will not be thirsty. Leon agrees and goes to ask Father Paul. The family sees the water as something that can help Teofilo and complete their care for him. In contrast, Father Paul initially connects the request to the Catholic rites the family has not followed. They include his holy water because it fits their purpose without requiring them to give up their traditional ceremony. (pp. 94-96)

Talking It Over (continued)

5. When Father Paul sprinkles the holy water on the grave, it falls "through the light from sundown like August rain. . . ." How does this image symbolize, or represent, the events of the story?

The image links the priest's holy water with the rain the family hopes Teofilo will send. The same water belongs to a Catholic ritual and also fits the family's traditional belief in rain and renewal. Father Paul's comparison to August rain briefly connects their different ways of understanding the burial. It also suggests life continuing after death, since rain can nourish the wilted squash flowers he remembers. The story ends with hope for rain; it does not show rain actually arriving. (p. 96)

6. What evidence in the story suggests that the Native Americans in this story move in two worlds-the world of the Christian workers and that of their traditional culture? What does the story suggest lies at "the heart of the matter" for the Native American characters?

The family lives among Christian influences while continuing its traditional customs. They know Father Paul, hear the church bells, and ask for holy water, yet they also use ceremonial paint, corn meal, pollen, and medicine bags. Everyday details such as the pickup truck and Levi's also appear alongside these customs. At the heart of the matter is caring for Teofilo, honoring their traditions, and maintaining the connection between their family, the dead, and the land. Leon's final hope for thunderclouds shows that the priest's water has become part of that purpose. (pp. 92-96)

7. What is the narrator's attitude toward these characters and their differing cultures? Do you think the story is told with sympathy for all the characters?

The narrator treats the family's beliefs with respect and presents its funeral customs as a natural part of life. I think the story also shows sympathy for Father Paul by revealing his tiredness, uncertainty, and eventual willingness to help. However, his suspicion that the burial might be a trick exposes his limited understanding and prejudice. The narrator is compassionate toward the characters while still allowing readers to notice the priest's mistakes. The ending stays closest to Leon's satisfaction and hope. (pp. 95-96)

Opening reflection

Think of how you have been affected by cultures other than your own-in the foods you eat, in the clothes you wear, and the music you enjoy.

Sample response to adapt to your own experience: Food, clothing, and music can introduce people to cultures beyond their own. Someone might enjoy another culture's food or music while still following their family's traditions. These influences can become part of everyday life without replacing a person's original culture. This connects to the story because Leon's family includes holy water in the burial while preserving its traditional beliefs.